

GENERATIONAL CLASH

Swagger and style:

Yamal and Ronaldo vie for the ball in the final. Portugal eventually won on penalties. AFP

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As European powerhouses Spain and Portugal prepared to face off in the UEFA Nations League final, the footballing world naturally took notice due to the sheer talent on show. But above all the stir, a particular narrative took centre stage. It was the first time the 40-year-old Cristiano Ronaldo faced the 17-year-old Lamine Yamal.

On paper, Spain, banking on the teenage sensation's unshakable swagger, seemed the favourite to lift the trophy. But at the end of the night, it was Ronaldo's towering presence that prevailed as he carried the trophy on his shoulder with a smirk on his face, just like he did six years ago.

A touch of class

While Spain began the game in its usual dominant fashion and took the lead through Martin Zubimendi, Portugal matched the tempo and quickly levelled courtesy of a clean, low shot from Nuno Mendes. Mikel

Oyarzabal, who scored the match-winning goal in the Euro 2024 final, seemed like he was going to be the hero again as he restored Spain's lead on the stroke of half-time.

Portugal kept the pressure on Spain, and on the stroke of the hour, it was Ronaldo himself who produced yet another clutch moment. When Mendes' deflected cross looped into the Spanish penalty box, left-back Marc Cucurella looked poised to clear it away. However, lurking behind him was the Portuguese captain, who volleyed in from close range to score his 138th international goal and make it 2-2.

It was his first and only shot of the game, and that was all he needed.

The strike gave Portugal a shot of belief as the players slowly started to wrest control from Spain. Carrying his momentum from his Champions League triumph with Paris Saint-Germain, Mendes stood out as one of the best on the pitch as he dampened Yamal's spark for most of the time, giving the youngster no room to breathe.

While Ronaldo failed to feature

past regulation time, his teammates piled on the pressure on their opponents and took the game to penalties. Portugal was flawless from the spot, while Spanish captain Alvaro Morata's attempt was saved by Diogo Costa.

Slice of history

As Ruben Neves buried the winning penalty into the back of the net, all eyes went to the touchline where Ronaldo fell to his knees with tears in his eyes. Winning has always been in his DNA, but this was extra special as Portugal became the first side to lift the Nations League title twice. "Winning for Portugal is always special. I have many titles with clubs, but nothing is better than winning for Portugal. It's tears. It's duty done and a lot of joy," Ronaldo said after the game.

On the other side, for Spain and Yamal, it was the end of an unbeaten run that stretched back to March 2023. And while the future may belong to the promising young star, he will have to wait his turn as the Portuguese talisman is yet to concede his crown.